but moved the capital to Hangzhou in Zhejiang province after being defeated by the Jin in 1127 CE . The Jin now controlled the territory north of the Yangzi river. Hereafter, the Song dynasty came to be known as the Southern Song. With the loss of the Central Asian trade routes, the Song began to promote maritime trade through the various ports on the country's eastern seaboard which were still under their control.

Despite having to rule over a smaller territory, the Song presided over an increasingly prosperous and relatively cosmopolitan empire. But while Tang cosmopolitanism was built on engagement with peoples and cultures towards the country's west, Song cosmopolitanism drew its inspiration from contact with the flourishing maritime kingdoms across the South China Sea and the Indian Ocean. India was part of both these cultural streams, having maintained trade links with China through Central Asia and South-East Asia. We have seen in the previous chapter that Indian influence in these maritime kingdoms was strong and sustained over time.

Song prosperity was based on significant advances in agriculture, innovative manufacturing processes and foreign trade. Rice cultivation in the newly colonized lands in the south rose with the use of new high-yielding varieties of paddy brought from South and South-East Asia. This generated large agricultural surpluses, which then supported urban settlement and trade. This was also an era of great technological advances, with Song Chinese innovations including the magnetic compass, gunpowder, movable type printing, and sophisticated shipbuilding and navigation techniques.

Chinese pottery too developed significantly with Song celadon – a luminous green glazed porcelain – becoming a much-sought-after trade item throughout South-East Asia and India. Celadon was particularly popular with the Islamic kingdoms and the Muslim aristocracy in India, and celadon-ware was custom-made for their use. Large celadon dishes for the traditional bara-khana are still found in India. These dishes were reputed to change colour if the food contained poison.[1]

China became the first country to introduce paper currency and an early version of the joint stock company. To spread the risk involved in long-